Mandate Reset



THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Work out who can make the decision you need, then ask for a specific change in how decisions get made.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

You’re responsible. But can you make the call?

You’re responsible for a release, but you can’t decide what waits when more work is added. Let’s take one of those decisions and work out what you need from the people involved.

Choose one decision

Start with a specific problem: who can approve adding another feature to this release? A conversation about that is easier to resolve than a general request for more authority.

Find out how it works today

Who brings the options? Who must be consulted? Whose approval is required? Who makes the final call? These may be different people.

Ask for a practical change

You might ask to make that decision within agreed limits. Or ask the person who retains it to respond within a day, with an agreed plan while you wait.

Check the answer

A new job title or a reassuring “you own it” doesn’t tell the team what to do. Ask the people involved to confirm the arrangement and use it on the next real request.

Here, your mandate means the decisions you’re actually allowed to make. The tool helps you ask for a clear answer about one of them.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

It's frustrating to be responsible for something you can't decide. Let's put that problem into words and leave room to hear how the other people see it.

What actually happened?

Start with what was said or done. "They asked for Friday" tells us what happened. "They don't care about the team" is an explanation you may have added. What could you ask to find out what's behind the request?

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? Perhaps a customer could stop chasing an answer, or your team could finish something it promised. Say why that matters to you, and ask what matters to the other person too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

These questions are for your own thinking; you can answer them without typing. If you use the Lab's private notes, they stay only in the open tab. They aren't saved or exported, and disappear when you refresh or leave.

An opening you can adapt: "I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make the problem easy to recognize.

“I need more authority” can mean many things. A real example gives you and your manager something you can work on together.

Describe the sequence

A director asks a developer for another feature. The developer starts it. I’m still asked to deliver the original plan on the original date.

Name the missing decision

Who can decide whether that feature enters this release, and what waits if it does? Keep the question that specific.

Ask how they see it

What do you understand me to be allowed to decide here? Has that been explained to the other directors and the team?

Invite a workable answer

I want us to give the team a plan it can follow. Could we agree who makes this call and how quickly we can get an answer?

You may need clearer permission, faster decisions, or people to honor an agreement that already exists. Find out which.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Who does what when this decision comes up?

Let's follow one decision from the request to the answer. Who gets involved along the way? Use names where you can, and note anything you need to check.

Who brings the options and advice?

One person prepares the recommendation. Others provide information: developers estimate the work, and an account manager explains customer promises. Giving advice doesn't automatically give someone the final say.

Whose approval is required?

For example, a security reviewer may have to approve the customer-data checks before release. A finance manager may have to approve extra spending. Keep those specific approvals clear.

Who makes the final call and carries it out?

Name who chooses what goes into the release, and who then builds, tests, communicates, or updates the plan. Also name who is expected to answer for the result.

Check your understanding

Is this written in a policy or agreement? Has the person confirmed it? Record what you have observed and what still needs checking. Someone influential may affect the choice without having formal permission to block it.

Further reading: Bain's RAPID decision roles

Use this map to check your understanding with the people named. Any change to who can decide still needs their agreement.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Who has which part of this decision?

Bain's RAPID names five roles: Recommend, Agree, Perform, Input, and Decide. Use them to check one decision with the people involved.

Recommend

One person gathers what matters and brings a proposal. Here, the PM compares the new request with the release plan.

Input and Agree

Input contributes knowledge and experience. Agree covers specific mandatory requirements. In this example, developers advise on effort; the security reviewer confirms the required customer-data checks.

Decide and Perform

Decide makes the final call. Perform carries it out. Here, the product director chooses the release work; developers implement it and the PM communicates the plan.

Check it with the people named

Ask them to confirm the roles, limits, and timing. Writing a person's name into the Lab does not grant authority or remove an approval.

RAPID is Bain & Company's framework. Follow the resource link for its full explanation; the Lab uses ordinary-language questions to help you apply the distinction.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What are you expected to deliver that you can't decide?

Let's connect the decision to the work. What are you expected to deliver, and what can't happen until someone makes the call?

Describe what happens

"Directors ask developers to add features. I can't postpone them, but I'm still expected to meet the original date." Someone else should be able to recognize that sequence.

Explain the effect

What waits? Who gets conflicting instructions? Which customer promise is now at risk? Use things you have seen. Label estimates as estimates.

Ask for one change

"Could all new requests go through the product director before they enter the plan?" Name the decision, the person, and any limits.

Keep necessary approvals

You're asking for a workable way to choose work. That doesn't remove required security, legal, or spending approvals. Include the people responsible for them.

Try: "I'm responsible for the date, but I can't choose what waits when new work arrives. Can we agree how those requests get decided?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make it easy to give you a clear answer.

A specific request is easier to answer. What would you like to be able to decide, or what response do you need from the person who keeps that decision?

If you’re asking to decide

Say which decision you want to make, for how long, and within which budget or other limits. Name any approvals that would still be required.

If someone else keeps the decision

Ask who you should contact, how soon they will respond, and what plan the team should follow while waiting. Don’t interpret no response as permission.

Ask when it can be agreed

Connect the date to the work. In the example, the team needs the arrangement confirmed before Monday's planning meeting.

Choose a way to check it

After the next two requests, ask whether someone made the call in time and the team received one clear plan. An agreement nobody uses needs another conversation.

Try: “If the decision stays with you, could you respond within one working day? Until then, can we keep the last agreed plan?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What would let the work move?

There can be more than one good answer. Prepare the change you want and an alternative that still gives the team a usable decision.

1 / What would you decide?

Could I postpone a new feature to protect the agreed release, within this budget and these required checks? Name the boundary as well as the permission.

2 / What would help you use that permission?

Do you need better information, help from Engineering, or a shared understanding of the customer goal? More authority alone may not solve it.

3 / If the call stays with them

Could you answer these requests within one working day? Who should we ask when you are unavailable? What should we do while waiting?

4 / Who needs to hear the agreement?

Could you confirm this with the directors and the developers? Ask what message would make the arrangement clear to the people using it.

Finish with who can decide what, the limits, a response time, and when you will check whether the arrangement is working.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Ask what they mean by “you own it.”

You may discover that leadership thinks you already have permission, or that an approval can’t move. Find out which problem you’re solving.

Start with the work

“I want the team to have one plan for the booking release. Here is what happens when a new request arrives, and where we get stuck.”

“You need to influence people”

“Who should I speak to, and who makes the final call? What should the team do while I’m getting an answer?”

“You already own it”

“Can I postpone a director's new request to protect the release date? If so, could you confirm that with the directors and the team?”

“We can’t give you that authority”

Ask for a timely decision from the person who keeps it. If no workable arrangement is agreed, record the problem and raise it through the appropriate manager. Stay within the authority you actually have.

The aim is a decision people can act on. You can be firm about the problem and still curious about what you don’t know.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A reassuring answer needs a practical test.

“Of course you own it” may be encouraging. The next request will show whether you have the same understanding of what that means.

Read the answer back

So the product director decides new release requests within one working day, and the team keeps the last agreed plan while waiting. Is that what we’re agreeing?

Make the limits clear

Keep required security, release, and spending approvals visible. A quicker way to choose work does not remove those responsibilities.

Tell the people who use it

Explain where to send requests, who responds, and what happens while waiting. Ask the director to resolve contradictory instructions from another director.

Return with an example

After two requests, compare the agreement with what happened. If the team still received conflicting instructions, describe those events and ask what needs changing.

The Lab’s updates and follow-up record help you keep the agreement connected to the work people actually experience.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Three directors. One release date.

Fictional example: a product manager is responsible for releasing an online repair-booking page. Several directors ask developers for extra features. Only the product director can approve changing the release plan.

The problem

I’m held responsible for the release date, but directors can add work and I can’t say what should wait. We don’t have any agreed way to get a quick decision.

The request

Send new requests to the product director before adding them to the team's plan. The director should say whether to add them now and, if they don’t fit, what should wait.

What stays in place

Security still approves the customer-data checks. Finance still approves extra spending. The engineering lead still confirms the software is ready. The request is about how new work enters the plan.

What happens next

In this example, the product director agrees to answer new requests within one working day and tells the other directors. The team keeps the last agreed plan while waiting. They check whether this worked after two requests. The Lab example starts before approval.

The product manager now knows how to get a decision. The product director keeps the final call and agrees when to make it.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Take one stuck decision through the Lab.

Start with the result expected of you and the decision you need to get there.

The problem

Record what you're responsible for, which decision is stuck, and what happens while you wait.

Who decides

Name the people who recommend, advise, approve, decide, and carry out the work. Preview Who Can Decide and ask them to check it.

What needs to change

Explain what you can't decide and the change you're requesting. Include limits and an alternative if the decision must stay with someone else. Preview The Decision Problem.

Ask and follow up

Name who needs to respond and by when. Preview Decision Request before the conversation. Return to record the answer, what you'll do while waiting, and when to check whether the arrangement works.

Choose Copy, Download .txt, or Print after reviewing the document. A proposal remains a proposal until the person agrees. Use Load Examples to see fictional answers for the current step. You'll be asked before existing answers are replaced.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What happened after the conversation?

Once you have talked, come back and see what changed. What helped, what still needs attention, and who needs to hear from you?

Follow up

Confirm the arrangement with everyone affected. On the next request, check who decided, how long it took, and whether the team knew what to do. If the same problem continues, bring that example back to the person who agreed to help.

Try saying it out loud

Read your message aloud. Does it sound like you? If a phrase feels awkward, use the words you'd say in the meeting. Someone you trust can help you spot anything that's hard to follow.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they don't follow you to another device. Private notes aren't saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence doesn't mean yes.

You don't have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you'll check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What kind of responsibility are people learning?

A workable decision process can help people use judgment and grow. An unclear one can teach them to wait, hide, or carry responsibility without help.

Identity

Are people learning that they can make a considered call and explain it? Or that being responsible means taking blame for choices they cannot make?

Relationship

Can directors and the team question each other without routing everything through private favors? What trust would make the arrangement easier to use?

Vision

Do people know enough about the purpose to choose well? What information would help them make a decision closer to the work?

Culture

Does the written arrangement survive a request from someone powerful? What does the response teach everyone else about whose judgment counts?

Notice what the arrangement makes possible for people, as well as how quickly decisions happen. Nobody needs to disclose personal health information to discuss the way work is organized.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

1 / The decision that gets stuck

The PM is responsible for a booking release. Developers keep receiving extra feature requests directly from directors. The PM chooses one question to resolve: who decides whether those requests enter this release?

PM

“I’m asked to protect the release date, but new features are being added directly. Can we look at how those requests get decided?”

Product director

“I thought you were already managing that. Show me where it’s getting stuck.”

Ask yourself: Can both people recognize the same sequence of events?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

2 / Check who does what

They map the recommendation, advice, required approvals, final call, and work afterward. The map is their current understanding, not a new grant of authority.

PM

“I can bring the options, and Engineering can explain the work. Do you make the final call about what enters the release?”

Product director

“Yes. Security still needs to approve the data checks, and Finance approves extra spending.”

Ask yourself: Have you separated giving advice, a required approval, and the final decision?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

3 / Ask for a usable arrangement

The PM asks for new requests to go through the product director before entering the team's plan. If the director keeps the decision, the PM asks for a response within one working day.

PM

"Could you make the call within one working day? And could the team keep the agreed plan until you answer?"

Product director

"That sounds workable. Let's make sure the other directors know where to send requests."

Ask yourself: Is that an agreement yet, or an encouraging response that still needs confirming?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

4 / Confirm it with everyone

In this fictional continuation, the director explicitly confirms the arrangement before Monday and tells the other directors and developers. The PM records the response time and the plan while waiting.

Product director

“Agreed. I’ll confirm this with everyone today. Bring me the options; keep the current plan until I decide.”

PM

“Let’s review how it works after the next two requests.”

Ask yourself: Would a developer receiving a new request know what to do now?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

5 / Use the next two requests

The first request gets a timely answer. The second stalls while the director is away. The PM brings that example back and asks for an authorized backup. This new request is still a proposal.

PM

“The first request worked well. The second waited while you were away. Who could make the call then?”

Product director

“Let me check who can cover that. Keep the agreed plan for now.”

Ask yourself: What did the real use reveal that the first agreement missed?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

The Hollow Crown: Why Our Leadership Narratives Have Failed

Nic Payne · Article

Use Nic's essay when the conversation keeps returning to whether you are a good enough leader instead of what the work requires.

Which conditions would need to change for someone else in this role to succeed too?

Take this into your Lab >

Do Your Replacement a Favor

Nic Payne · Article

Consider whether the arrangement could work without your private favors and constant intervention.

Could someone new understand how this decision gets made?

Take this into your Lab >

Leadership: participating and being changed

Nic Payne · Video · start at 13:45

Nic describes leadership as participating in relationships and being changed by them. Use it to stay open to what the other people see.

What might I need to change in my own understanding of this role?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

[You Have a Culture Problem]

Nic Payne · Article

Look at how authority, trust, and a shared purpose influence each other over time.

What does our decision process teach people about whose judgment matters?

Take this into your Lab >

[When Mattering Isn't Enough]

Nic Payne · Article

Nic asks what comes after feeling valued. Consider what support people need to grow into the responsibility they have been given.

Where could a clearer agreement reduce harm and make growth possible?

Take this into your Lab >

[RAPID® Decision Making]

Bain & Company · Originator's framework explanation

Read Bain's explanation of Recommend, Agree, Perform, Input, and Decide alongside your Who Can Decide record.

Do the people named agree that these are their roles for this decision?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

Control In An Emergency

L. David Marquet · Author's Leadership Nudge transcript and embedded video

Marquet's article and video connect authority with the understanding needed to use it well.

What knowledge and shared purpose would help us move this decision closer to the work?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 01

You cannot carry every missing decision yourself.

"No one, no matter how well-intentioned, can out-serve a broken system."

Nic Payne · The Magic of Mr. Greenleaf — A Servant Leader's Guide to the Impossible

Nic's Greenleaf essay asks what happens when good people are expected to make a broken arrangement work through personal sacrifice. If you must privately persuade three directors every time the plan changes, name that pattern. Your request can help everyone know how the next decision will be made.

Worth asking: What currently depends on you absorbing a problem nobody has agreed to fix?

The Magic of Mr. Greenleaf — A Servant Leader's Guide to the Impossible
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 03

Separate advice, approval, and the final call.

Bain's RAPID framework distinguishes the person recommending a decision, people giving input, people whose agreement is required, the final decision maker, and those doing the work. Use that distinction to check your map with the people involved. Writing someone's name in the Lab does not give them new authority.

Worth asking: Have the people named here agreed that this is how the decision works?

RAPID® Decision Making
Bain & Company · Originator's framework explanation

CHAPTER 04

What does "owning it" do to a person here?

Holistic Shaping asks how everyday arrangements help people grow or cause harm. Responsibility without a way to decide can teach someone to keep quiet, seek permission for everything, or cover the gap with longer hours. Describe what is happening and ask for a workable decision arrangement, with the support needed to use it.

Worth asking: What would let you exercise judgment and learn, rather than merely carry the consequences?

[C]ulture → [V]ulture
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 05

Make the arrangement usable without you.

Write down which decision this covers, who answers, how soon, and what happens while people wait. Try it on the next real request and review it together. The aim is a way of working that another person could understand, not another private favour you must keep asking for.

Worth asking: Could someone new use this agreement without knowing whom to approach behind the scenes?

Do Your Replacement a Favor
Nic Payne · Article

Clarity Contract
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

CHAPTER 09

Notice whether people's place in the work changes.

A clear decision arrangement can change more than response times. People may become more willing to take responsibility, offer an idea, or admit what they do not know. In the orbital model, those experiences shape who people understand themselves to be and how they relate. Ask whether the new arrangement is doing that in practice.

Worth asking: Are people gaining room to contribute, or has permission simply moved to a different person?

You Have a Culture Problem
Nic Payne · Article

Explore more of Nic's Holistic Shaping work at Rebel Leaders.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.